

ASSESSMENT OF ORAL LANGUAGE: TOOLS AND STRATEGIES

*Notes**8.1 Introduction**8.2 Learning Outcomes**8.3 Oral Language Development**8.4 Assessment of Oral Language**8.5 Listening Skills**8.6 Elicit Responses**8.7 Let Us Sum Up**8.8 End Exercises**8.9 References*

8.1 INTRODUCTION

In continuation to previous chapters, particularly to Chapter 2, which focused on oral language development in L2, this chapter focuses on equipping teachers with tools and strategies to assess oral language proficiency. Let us begin by asking a simple question. Should oral language proficiency amongst children ever be assessed? If yes, then why and how should it be done? This particular chapter will help us to understand the importance of assessing oral language development in L2. While some theoretical aspects of oral language are discussed, the major part of the chapter focuses on classroom practice, with an emphasis on tools and strategies to assess different aspects of oral language proficiency. The chapter highlights observation and documentation as key assessment methods of oral language proficiency in L2.

Let's reiterate briefly some of the assumptions regarding oral language development in L2. First, the classroom encourages children to use multiple

Planning and
Assessment*Notes*

languages, especially in the early years, for literacy development. L1 is used to scaffold language development in the second language. The teacher respects the child's language and encourages the use of their language to develop literacy. The classroom has a rich resource of print, such as storybooks, charts, flashcards, toffee wrappers, and so on, and writing materials such as paper, chalk, pencils, colours, etc. Children participate in peer-to-peer, teacher-child interactions in small group, large group, and whole group projects/activities. The assessment is largely continuous and comprehensive, with the objective of learning.

Research shows that a classroom that supports second language development has some common features, such as starting with what children already know, repeating and practicing specific linguistic components, tailoring questions as per the language level of the children, using storytelling and storybooks, and providing opportunities for role-play and conversations amongst children and between child and teacher. It is easier to push young children to begin writing or reading in a second language, but supporting oral language skills is believed to result in better reading and writing in the later years.

The lesson has five sections. In the first section, we will briefly discuss different aspects of oral language and its relationship with reading. The second section is on assessment and different tools of assessment, such as observation checklists, anecdotal records, and oral performance rubrics. The next three sections highlight listening and speaking skills with sample activities and built-in sample assessments.

**8.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of the lesson, the learner:

- Demonstrates knowledge of different aspects of oral language;
- Prepares age-appropriate tools such as observation checklists, anecdotal records, oral performance rubrics, and listening-response activities to assess children's L2 oral proficiency;
- Plans activities using songs and poetry to enable children to identify and repeat sounds and also follow oral directions in L2;
- Uses picture cues, story maps, or real-life objects to elicit children's responses in L2 to organise and present oral narratives;
- Organises activities for children to narrate experiences or stories in sequence with clarity, rhythm, and appropriate intonation.

8.3 ORAL LANGUAGE DEVELOPMENT

What is the role of oral language in reading and writing? Before we begin to respond to this question, let us look at another set of questions: What do we mean by oral language? And what are the different aspects of oral language?

8.3.1 Oral Language and its Components

Simply put, oral language is a meaningful group of words that is orally spoken to communicate thoughts and feelings. Let's break down oral language into different components to better understand the importance of oral language proficiency in literacy development. Oral language is made up of phonology, grammar, morphology, vocabulary, discourse, and pragmatics. We need to keep in mind that these components are most important in the reading and writing development. We will briefly discuss each of the components below.

8.3.1.1 Phonology

Phonology is a system of sounds within a language. It is important to know about phonological awareness and phonemic awareness as they are found to be key predictors of reading in children. Phonological awareness is the awareness of words in sentences or syllables in words. It also includes rhyme, alliteration, and word families. Phonemic awareness is the awareness of individual sounds (phonemes), such as, there are three phonemes in the word 'cat'—/k/, /a/, /t/. Knowing the phonemes helps in blending, segmenting, and manipulating them in words.

8.3.1.2 Vocabulary (Semantics)

The development of vocabulary focuses on both Expressive Vocabulary and Receptive Vocabulary. By Expressive vocabulary, it means the words that a student actively uses while communicating either in speech or in writing. But the words that a student understands on the basis of context and background experience, and knowledge are called Receptive vocabulary. The student may not necessarily use it on an everyday basis.

8.3.1.3 Grammar (Syntax)

Grammar is a set of rules that governs how words and phrases come together in a sentence in a given language. Children begin to know the rules of a language as they develop their oral language proficiency.



Notes

Planning and
Assessment

Notes

8.3.1.4 Morphology

Morphology is focused on the smallest units of meaning within a word and the rules about how those words are formed. For example, the word “cats” has four phonemes (/k/, /a/, /t/, and /s/), but only two morphemes (meaningful word parts). “Cat” is an animal, and “s” tells us that there is more than one cat.

8.3.1.5 Pragmatics

A speaker of a language knows and uses language with peers and authority figures differently. Similarly, the speaker knows about turn-taking, personal space, etc., while speaking. Pragmatics is the knowledge of language in social situations. It is primarily concerned with meaning.

Meaning is conveyed through phrasing, intonation, stress, and rhythm, which combined together is called prosody. Phrasing is smaller chunks of meaning in a given sentence. Pause plays an important role in differentiating between words, phrases, and sentences. While intonation is the change in pitch of the spoken words, stress is the emphasis on certain syllables of the word or words in a given sentence, and rhythm is the pattern of spoken words in a language. On the whole, prosody informs us about the nature of the sentence (a statement, a question, or an exclamation) and the fact that the words put together is a complete sentence conveying an idea.

8.3.1.6 Discourse

By discourse, it means oral and written communication. Stories, events, and anecdotes have different structures. To know these structures, children must be exposed to a variety of situations and texts.

8.3.2 Relationship between Oral Language and Reading

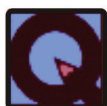
Oral language development is the foundation for literacy development. It is a prerequisite for reading with comprehension. Oral skills help to engage children in classroom interactions, which leads to learning vocabulary and comprehension skills. We know that oral skills scaffold in the development of background knowledge and context. Importantly, oral language skills contribute to the development of a mental representation of text. This implies that when a child possesses a strong vocabulary and a clear understanding of the structural components of language, they are able to construct mental images of spoken or printed words, facilitating deeper comprehension.

Children actively listen to the spoken language around them. It means that as they listen to the spoken language, they make hypotheses about, look for patterns in the language, and test their prediction as well (Teale & Sulzby, 1989).

Oral language development ensures children's reading and writing abilities in both L1 and L2. Research shows that oral language is the foundation for beginning reading as children draw on the vocabulary, meaning, syntax, phonology, and discourse of spoken language. A child who has a broader vocabulary in spoken language has a better chance of decoding and reading with meaning. Similarly, a child who knows the structures of different texts, such as stories, anecdotes, and events, will be attuned to and knows what to expect when they begin to read a given text.



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CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 8.1

1. Fill in the blanks:

- i. The different components of language are phonology, grammar, _____, morphology, pragmatics, and discourse.
- ii. There are _____ phonemes in the word 'table'.
- iii. There are _____ morphemes in the word 'table'.

2. Tick 'True' or 'False' against each statement.

- i. Oral language skills are not required for reading with comprehension.
- ii. Discourse, a component of language, refers to the social use of language.

Answers:

1. (i) vocabulary, (ii) five, (iii) one
2. (i) False, (ii) True

8.4 ASSESSMENT OF ORAL LANGUAGE

It is well known that effective instruction for oral language development starts with effective oral language assessment. Using process-based assessments, which include observation and documentation, you can plan lessons as per the requirements of your children while keeping in mind the curriculum objectives. It can help in providing a safe and nurturing learning environment. Such assessment must be incorporated into the teacher's daily practice. They are helpful in two ways. First, they help to assess and monitor their progress, and secondly, recalibrate learning outcomes for each child.

Planning and
Assessment

Notes

According to the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (2023), assessment at the foundational stage must be based on “observations of the child and analyzing artefacts that the child has created as part of their learning experience” (p. 103). The formative assessment methods must continue at the preparatory stage alongside assessments that “test conceptual understanding and competencies, and should include questions that encourage creativity” (p. 104).

There are several tools to assess language proficiency, such as observation checklists, anecdotal records, portfolios, oral performance rubrics etc. In the following section, we will discuss three strategies--- observation checklists, anecdotal records, and oral performance rubrics. We will discuss portfolios in Chapter 10 in details.

8.4.1 Observation Checklists

As the name suggests, an observation checklist is a checklist with certain observable indicators for the given skill that the child is being assessed for. One has to mark the frequency of the observable indicators. Frequency is represented as Always, Often, Sometimes, Seldom, Never. The child must be observed in different situations before recording the observations in the checklist. Given below is an observation checklist to assess phonological awareness.

Table 8.1: Observation Checklist to Identify Sounds in Small Words

	Always	Often	Sometimes	Seldom	Never
Can identify initial sounds (the first sound in ‘dog’)					
Can identify final sounds in words (e.g., “What’s the last sound in ‘dog?’”)					
Can identify rhyming words					
Can distinguish sounds in similar-sounding words such as ‘sit’, ‘sat’, and ‘set’					

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8.4.2 Oral Performance Rubrics

Oral performance rubrics are a rubric which on one side has indicators and on the other has a scale to measure the performance against the indicators. The scale can be in terms of numbers (from 1 to 4/5), with each level having graded descriptions or phrases like ‘good’, ‘needs improvement’, ‘developing’, and ‘excellent’, or use visuals such as, the number of smiley faces/ stars. The rubric depends on the developmental stage of the child and the task assigned.

Table 8.2: Oral Performance Rubric to Assess Oral Skills

	Excellent	Good	Trying	Needs improvement
Makes eye contact with the audience				
Speaks clearly				
Speaks at an appropriate volume				
Uses topic-specific words				

8.4.3 Anecdotal Records

Anecdotal records are brief notes based on close observations of children (Clay 2001). These are short descriptions of specific observations documenting important events or behaviours. The detailed record of events or behaviours through anecdotal records helps in tracking milestones, identifying patterns, and recognising individual strengths and areas for growth.

Some key points to keep in mind while writing an anecdotal record:

- An anecdotal record must respond to the questions such as who, where, when, what, and how. It must also include the curriculum area and learning outcome description.
- It is written in the past tense.
- Note down the exact words used in the interaction and response. Use

Planning and
Assessment

Notes

specific language to describe what the child said and did, including facial expression and tone of voice.

- Avoid interpretations, opinions, or judgments. Do not summarise behaviour or how the child is feeling.
- Write the record as soon as possible after the event.
- Keep a notebook or sticky notes to scribble specific words, phrases to help you with the description.

Sample Anecdotal Record

When: Wednesday, 12/09/2024; 12:22 pm

Class I

Where: Classroom, Whole group

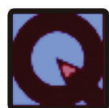
Who: Swaraj

Curriculum area or domain: Estimation and numbers

What: I showed flash cards with certain number of beads on it to the group and hid it. I asked each one to guess the number. I showed the flashcard with 12 beads with 6 on top and 6 below. Swaraj looked at it and began counting on his fingers—one, two, three, four, five and six. Then taking a little time, he said, 'twelve'.

According to Espinosa and Magruder (2015), it is helpful to keep some points to keep in mind as one does observation-based assessments. Preparation is the key to observational assessment. It means that you must identify beforehand (a) three/four students you will be observing, (b) the target area of development, (c) time, if possible, and (d), if needed, what time of the day you can interact with the child. Observation, as discussed earlier, must be recorded in an authentic learning situation. Therefore, the child's / children's exact words must be noted, not what you think. To observe the growth of the child in that specific domain, you have to observe regularly over a period of time and in different situations. Each observation may cover some curricular objectives, so you have to identify specific objectives during the planning time.

Moreover, observation and recording of students' behaviours may make students a bit uncomfortable initially. But if it is done regularly, then the children will get used to it and behave quite naturally, making the whole process of assessment ideal for learning.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 8.2**

1. Match the following.

Column A	Column B
i. Oral performance rubric	a. Frequency of observable indicators
ii. Anecdotal record	b. Description of observable indicators
iii. Observation checklist	c. Short and specific descriptions in the past tense

2. Tick any one of the following:

- i. Characteristics of process-based assessments are:
 - a. Monitors children's progress
 - b. They are usually done at the end of the unit or term
 - c. Observation and documentation obstruct children's learning
 - d. None of the above
- ii. In the anecdotal record, the teacher writes:
 - a. In the past tense
 - b. Writes immediately after the behaviour/ event
 - c. Note down exact words used by the child/ children
 - d. All of the above

Answers:

1. i-b, ii-c, iii-a
2. (i) a. (ii) d.

8.5 LISTENING SKILLS

It is important that children are exposed to the target language through different activities. Listening to the language is crucial for their language development. Children must be given language inputs, and most importantly, how language works in a given social situation. As children are young, the language inputs must be given and their assessment done in a meaningful and developmentally appropriate manner. We will discuss below certain specific areas to foster listening skills in children.

*Notes*

Planning and
Assessment

Notes

8.5.1 Identification and Repetition of Sounds

The sonority of words makes any language distinct. Words are the fundamental units of a language. They are meaningful units of sounds. It is therefore important that children are given enough opportunities to listen to different sounds in the English language and repeat them through word play, songs, rhymes, and poetry. In that way, they can distinguish different sounds in a word (beginning, middle, and end sounds) and different chunks in a sentence.

Below are some poems and songs that employ alliteration, rhyme, onomatopoeia, repetition, and rhythm, making them enjoyable while reciting and singing them. They help in supporting phonological awareness, phonemic awareness, phrasing, vocabulary, and so on.

Activity 8.1 Repeat the Sound (Grades I/II)

This activity helps to develop the concept of a distinct sound, that is phoneme. The teacher takes a rhyme or a poem and asks children to repeat it after her. After repeating it 3-4 times, she changes the first sound of each word to another phoneme. She continues it with different phonemes each time they sing the rhyme/ poem.

*Row, row, row your boat
Gently down the stream.
Merrily, merrily, merrily, merrily;
Life is but a dream.*

**Bow, bow, bow your boat
Bentley bown the bream.
Berrily, berrily, berrily, berrily;
Bife is but a bream.
Fow, fow, fow your foat
Fently fown the fream.
Ferrily, ferrily, ferrily, ferrily;
Fife is fut a fream.**



Activity 8.2 I Spy with Syllables (Grades II/III)

This activity helps to develop the concept of syllables. The teacher chooses objects around the classroom. She breaks the word into syllables and says them slowly. For example, the teacher chooses ‘table’ and says, **“I spy with my little eye: a ta....ble.”** Students have to say the complete word, which is ‘table’.

After a few rounds, you might choose a student to be the next leader and choose the objects.

Activity 8.3 Stomp My Sentence (Grade IV/V)

This activity helps to develop the concept of words. Frame a sentence. Say it aloud while students listen. Then, students should stand up and repeat the exact same sentence. Each time they hear a word, they stomp one foot.

8.5.2 Follow Oral Directions (Grades I-V with Variations)

It is important that children understand the language they hear. They need to be given various listening opportunities. Games and activities that can enhance children’s ability to follow directions in L2 are given below.

Activity 8.4 Simon Says (for Grades I/II)

This game aims to encourage children to follow instructions carefully. The teacher gives a command by saying ‘Simon says—hop like a frog!’ Following the instruction, students hop like a frog.

Activity 8.5 Mind the Words (Grade IV/V)

This activity is to enhance listening skills by following the words the teacher says instead of what she does. The teacher says a sentence such as ‘Touch your toes’ but she touches her shoulders instead. The students need to follow the sentence by bending down and touching their toes with their hands.

Activity 8.6 Draw This (Grade II/III/IV/V)

This activity encourages children to listen attentively and follow the instructions. The teacher gives short and specific directions to draw. Children have to listen to the instructions and draw on paper. For example, the instructions may be:

“In the centre of the page, draw a large rectangle.”

“Now, draw a triangle on top of the rectangle.”

“Draw two small squares in the rectangle.”

Planning and
Assessment

Notes

The teacher can then ask students to show their papers. She can gradually read each instruction and draw on the blackboard, and students can check their drawings. The task can be made difficult/easier depending on the grade and the level of the students' proficiency in the language.

Activity 8.7 Loop and Repeat (Grade I-V with variations)

This activity enhances memory and active listening in children. The first child says the name of a fruit, the second child repeats the first word and adds another fruit. The third child repeats the names of fruits said earlier and adds the third fruit, and it continues. For younger children, it can be simple words, but for older (Class V) ones, it can be short sentences.

Activity 8.8 True or False (Grade I-V with variations)

Through this activity, students learn to listen to the story carefully, enjoy it, and remember the characters, setting, and plot. The teacher either reads aloud from the story or narrates a story to the children. After the read aloud or narration, the teacher says some statements related to the story, and the students have to say either 'True' or 'False'.

Activity 8.9 Jumble-Fumble (Grade IV/V)

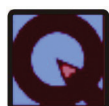
The teacher chooses a poem/song that has a lot of wordplay. The teacher displays the poem poster. By using voice modulation, facial expression, and gestures, she asks children to repeat after her. Through this activity, children enjoy the language due to the play of sounds, and learn different vocabulary. For example, Dr. Seuss's poem "One Fish, Two Fish, Red Fish, Blue Fish."

8.5.3 Assessment of Listening Skills

Depending on the learning outcome/s, a teacher may decide to choose different strategies to assess oral language development. Let's take one learning outcome of oral language development in the English language for Grade 2 as suggested by the NCERT: *listens to instructions and draws a picture* (2017, p. 26). You can choose a game such as 'Simon Says' or 'Draw This' and identify any four students in the class to assess the given learning outcome. You can decide on recording behaviours either on an observation checklist or an anecdotal record for each student. A sample checklist is given below.

**Table 8.3: Observation Checklist for the Learning Outcome
(Listens to Instructions and Draws a Picture)**

	Always	Often	Sometimes	Seldom	Never
Is prepared with pencil and paper					
Listens attentively					
Asks for instructions to be repeated					
Seeks help from friends					
Draws without using an eraser					

*Notes***CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 8.3**

Write 'True' or 'False' against each statement.

1. Listening skills are not related to reading with meaning.
2. Activities focusing on sounds and sound patterns strengthen vocabulary in children.
3. Children must learn to follow instructions in L2 to discipline themselves.

Answers:

1. False, 2. True, 3. False

8.6 ELICIT RESPONSES

One learns a language by listening as well as speaking the language. In the beginning years, they may be asked to repeat and use single words and simple short sentences. By Class V, students are expected to use simple sentences to communicate and express their thoughts and feelings in L2. Children must be given ample opportunities to practice speaking. They should be able to organise and narrate personal experiences, events, or simple stories using chronological order and relevant details, demonstrating natural rhythm and clarity, appropriate

Planning and
Assessment

Notes

intonation for questions, statements, and emotions. With regular practice of language through games and activities based on environmental print—such as storybooks, charts, calendars, and flashcards—children develop concepts of print, such as identifying the front and back of a book, tracking print from left to right and top to bottom, making letter–sound associations, and beginning to recognise words.

8.6.1 Organise and Present Oral Narratives

Children are encouraged to use L2 to organise and present oral narratives. In this way, they learn to use language in their daily life. They describe a given subject, give instructions, ask questions, turn taking, etc.

Children also must be exposed to and have opportunities to use the academic aspect of language as much as the communicative aspect of language. Instructions, whether receiving, giving, or reading, are crucial aspects of academic language.

Activity 8.10 Show and Tell

Through this activity, children learn different vocabulary to describe the object. They also learn the structure of how to describe an object.

In the early years (Class I/II), the teacher may ask them to bring a toy from home. He/She may guide the children by telling them three sentences to speak.

First sentence: This is a _____ (name of the object).

Second sentence: It is _____ and _____ (describing words).

Third sentence: I like it because _____ (the reason).

With the older children, the teacher may give an object present in the classroom and ask each child to say five sentences on it.

Activity 8.11 Draw and Tell

Through this activity, children learn to narrate their stories using drawings. They may first illustrate their story and later, during circle time, share the drawing while narrating the story they created. In the early years, the narration may consist of only a few words, but by Class V, learners are expected to express their stories in 5–6 sentences.



Activity 8.12 *Guess, Where am I Going?*

Through this activity, children learn to give directions in L2. This activity is for children in classes IV and V. Children select one specific room/ part of the school and accordingly give directions from their classroom to their classmates. At the end of the directions, she/he asks, ‘Where am I going?’

8.6.2 Narrate Personal Experiences, Events, or Simple Stories

It is important that children get to use L2 for various purposes. Dialogue, narrating stories, and events increase their vocabulary. They also deepen their knowledge of different structures of the narratives (story, event, social situation).

Activity 8.13 *Story in a Picture*

Take a poster (Phirkee Bachchon Ki). It is a wordless picture. Children can be asked what they see. For younger children, the teacher may point to different objects, people, events, and describe them in single words or sentences in L2. For older children (Grades 4 & 5), the teacher may ask the students to use simple sentences to describe the picture.

I see a _____. He/she is going to _____. I think he/she likes _____.
When I go to _____ I also like to _____.

Activity 8.14 *Pick and Share (Grades IV/V)*

The teacher and children sit in a circle. Give the first person to start the story by pulling an object from the bag and saying the first two lines of the story. The second person picks another toy and continues the story. The third child pulls another object and finishes the story. The teacher can give some cues, such as:

1. Beginning—‘Once upon a time, there was a ...He lived in a’
2. Middle—A problem in the story
3. End—Ending, probably with an interesting note

The game can be played another way by giving the bag to one child and letting them pull two to three toys and narrate the whole story.

Activity 8.15 *Let’s Pretend*

Through this activity, the children learn to use language relevant to specific situations. They learn to use vocabulary, turn-taking, pace, and intonation when they communicate in a given social situation.

Planning and
Assessment

Notes

The teacher assigns roles to students of everyday scenarios such as ‘shopkeeper-customer’, ‘doctor-patient’, ‘conductor of a bus-passenger’. The teacher may give cues to guide children (of class III) for appropriate language use. Such as for the doctor-patient role play:

Patient: Good morning, Doctor!

Doctor: Good morning!

Patient: Ma’am, I have... Since ... days.

Doctor: Let me see...

Doctor: I have written down some medicines / This is the prescription.

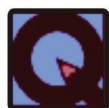
Patient: Thank you!

8.6.3 Assessment of Speaking Skills

One of the learning outcomes for oral language proficiency in English language, grade V, as suggested by the NCERT is: *answers coherently in written or oral form to questions in English based on day-to-day life experiences, unfamiliar story, poem heard or read* (2017, p. 30). Let’s see how we can assess an individual child’s oral language proficiency with the given learning outcome. Here is a sample checklist for the task based on a read-aloud of a story titled “The Grand Patch-up” (StoryWeaver, n.d.).

Table 8.4: Observation Checklist for the Learning Outcome (Answers Coherently Orally to Questions in English Based on the Story Titled)

	Yes	No	Sometimes	Never
Listened attentively to the story read aloud				
Responded to the story emotionally				
Shared incidents from her life				
Asked questions during read-aloud				
Used the English language to ask questions or to respond to questions				
Used complete sentences in the English language				



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 8.4

Write 'True' or 'False' against each statement.

1. Speaking skills discourage children from writing.
2. Through different activities/ games, children learn about different structures of a story or an event.
3. Role plays do not help in the development of speaking skills.

Answers:

1. False, 2. True, 3. False



8.7 LET US SUM UP

- Language is a broad set of rules related to sounds and sound patterns, semantic units, sentence structures, as well as discourse-level processes and structures.
- Developing these language components, such as vocabulary or phonological and phonemic awareness, has shown better results in reading comprehension.
- Process-based assessment tools help in monitoring each child's progress and designing activities suitable for each child's skills.
- There are assessment tools such as observation checklists, anecdotal records, and oral performance rubrics to assess oral proficiency.
- The observation checklist indicates the frequency of observable behaviours of oral proficiency.
- Anecdotal records are short and specific observations of events or behaviours.
- An oral performance rubric is a descriptive rubric of observable behaviours of oral proficiency.
- By engaging in poetry rich in word play, alliteration, rhymes, and personification, children's concept about print develops, such as different sounds combine together to form words, words are made up of syllables, and words combine together to form meaningful phrases or sentences.



Notes

Planning and
Assessment*Notes*

- Children learn about phrasing, intonation, and rhythm in speech.
- Through different activities/ games, teachers can enhance one or two specific components of oral language.
- Through different activities/games, children can be given opportunities to use specific words (vocabulary) or sentences in specific contexts, making learning language meaningful and enjoyable.
- games and activities based on print in the environment, children learn concepts about print.
- Children learn about phrasing, intonation, and rhythm in speech.
- Depending on the specific linguistic curricular goal, children can be assessed using different strategies.

**8.8 END EXERCISES**

1. Name the different components of language. Explain with an example each.
2. Which assessment tool will you use to assess phonemic awareness? Write in detail.
3. What are the do's and don'ts of anecdotal records?
4. When can we use an oral performance rubric? Give an example.
5. How will you assess speaking skills? Explain with an activity and assessment tool.
6. Make or collect one game/ activity each to enhance listening and speaking skills in the second language. Mention the appropriate grades against each game/ activity.
7. Why must we assess oral language development in a second language?
8. Collect/ Make two games/activities each for listening and speaking skills.

8.9 REFERENCES

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